C M Y K

Nxxx,2026-03-25,A,001,Bs-4C,E1

"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

VOL. CLXXV .... No. 60,834 © 2026 The New York Times Company WEDNESDAY, MARCH 25, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00

THE WEATHER
Today, morning sunshine, afternoon clouds, warmer, high 52. **Tonight,** mostly cloudy, low 45. **Tomorrow,** partly sunny, warmer, high 68. Weather map appears on Page B8.

DAVE SANDERS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

No Movement on Long Lines

At LaGuardia Airport, still reeling from a crash, security delays disrupted travel. A funding deal in Congress faces hurdles. Page A15.

Saudi Prince Said to Urge U.S. to Continue Iran War

Pressed for Airstrikes on Energy Facilities to Weaken the Government in Tehran

*This article is by **Julian E. Barnes**, **Tyler Pager** and **Eric Schmitt**.*

WASHINGTON — Saudi Arabia's de facto leader, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, has been pushing President Trump to continue the war against Iran, arguing that the U.S.-Israeli military campaign presents a "historic opportunity" to remake the Middle East, according to people briefed by American officials on the conversations.

In a series of conversations over the last week, Prince Mohammed has conveyed to Mr. Trump that he must press toward the destruction of Iran's hard-line government, the people familiar with the conversations said.

Prince Mohammed, the people familiar with the discussions said, has argued that Iran poses a long-term threat to the Gulf that can only be eliminated by getting rid of the government.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel also views Iran as a long-term threat, but analysts say Israeli officials would probably view a failed Iranian state that is too caught up in internal turmoil to menace Israel as a win, while Saudi Arabia views a failed state in Iran as a grave and direct security threat.

But senior officials in both the Saudi and American governments worry that if the conflict drags on, Iran could deliver ever more punishing attacks on Saudi oil installations and the United States could be stuck in an endless war.

In public, Mr. Trump has swung wildly between suggesting that the war could end soon and signaling it would escalate. On Monday, the president posted on social media that his administration and Iran had held "productive conversations regarding a complete and total resolution of our hostilities," though Iran disputed the idea that negotiations were underway.

The consequences of the war for Saudi Arabia's economy and national security are enormous. Iranian drone and missile attacks, launched in response to the American-Israeli assault on Iran, have already created huge disruptions in the oil market.

Saudi officials rejected the idea that Prince Mohammed has pushed to prolong the war.

"The kingdom of Saudi Arabia has always supported a peaceful resolution to this conflict, even before it began," the Saudi government said in a statement, noting that officials "remain in close contact with the Trump administration and our commitment remains unchanged."

"Our primary concern today is to defend ourselves from the daily attacks on our people and our civilian infrastructure," the government added. "Iran has chosen dangerous brinkmanship over serious diplomatic solutions. This harms every stakeholder involved but none more than Iran itself."

KENNY HOLSTON/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Mohammed bin Salman.

Mr. Trump has at times seemed open to winding down the war, but Prince Mohammed has argued that would be a mistake, the people briefed on the conversations said, and has pressed for attacks against Iran's energy infrastructure to weaken the government in Tehran.

This article is based on interviews with people who have had conversations with American officials, and who described the discussions on the condition of ano-

Continued on Page A9

SHIELD A Ukrainian energy company's use of drones could be a model for the Mideast. PAGE A10

At LaGuardia, Disaster Struck In 20 Seconds

By CHRISTOPHER MAAG

It took 20 seconds for a routine landing at LaGuardia Airport on Sunday night to devolve into a fatal disaster.

Air Canada Express Flight 8646 was about 100 feet above the ground when an air traffic controller gave permission for a fire truck to cross LaGuardia's Runway No. 4.

Eleven seconds later, a controller in the LaGuardia tower started yelling over the radio at the fire truck's driver to stop immediately, Doug Brazy, a senior aviation accident investigator with the National Transportation Safety Board, said at a news conference on Tuesday afternoon.

One second after that, the plane touched down on the runway, Mr. Brazy said. Three seconds later, the captain assumed control of the plane from the first officer. The jet rolled on the tarmac for another seven seconds, braking hard. Then the two vehicles collided, the nose of the plane imploding, the fire truck flipping on its side, debris spraying across the tarmac. Both pilots died; both firefighters were injured but survived.

The first investigators arrived before sunrise on Monday morning. The rest of the team assembled slowly, as air safety experts faced the same delays as other Americans attempting to travel during a partial federal government shutdown.

Forty hours after the disaster, many facts remained unknown, Jennifer Homendy, the chairwoman of the National Transportation Safety Board, said, including what exactly caused the

Continued on Page A13

Epstein Acted as the Fixer for a Billionaire Friend

Sorting Out Problems With Women, Along With His Taxes

*This article is by **Matthew Goldstein**, **Jessica Silver-Greenberg**, **Steve Eder** and **David Enrich**.*

In October 2017, a yoga instructor emailed Jeffrey Epstein with a delicate question: When might she receive the tens of thousands of dollars she'd been promised by the billionaire Leon Black?

She and Mr. Black had been in a sexual relationship, and since at least 2009, hundreds of thousands of dollars had flowed to her from Mr. Black's bank accounts. But in 2017, the setup changed. Now Mr. Epstein would wire the money — in this case, $100,000.

"He said that now he does it through you," the woman wrote to Mr. Epstein in an email that the Justice Department released this year. Mr. Epstein wrote back, confirming the arrangement.

In the later years of Mr. Epstein's life, after he was incarcerated and registered as a sex offender, no one did more to bankroll his opulent lifestyle than Mr. Black, 74, a towering figure on Wall Street and a fixture of the global art scene.

Mr. Black paid Mr. Epstein $170 million over six years for what Mr. Black has said were tax and estate-planning services. The sum dwarfed what elite law or accounting firms would have charged for similar work, baffling both his Wall Street peers and investigators on Capitol Hill.

The millions of pages of Epstein-related emails and other documents that the Justice Department released this year offer a potential explanation for the size of the payments: Mr. Epstein essentially served as a fixer whose

Continued on Page A20

LAUREN DeCICCA FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

High and Dry in a Fuel Crunch

Thai fishermen who can't buy diesel are stuck in port as Southeast Asia feels war's effects. Page A6.

Starmer Slips From Trump Ally To Punchline and Punching Bag

A 'Special Relationship' Sours Over a War

By MICHAEL D. SHEAR

LONDON — It's now crystal clear what President Trump thinks of Prime Minister Keir Starmer of Britain.

Over the weekend, Mr. Trump shared on social media a brutal skit from Britain's new version of the "Saturday Night Live" show, portraying the prime minister as overly eager to please the president and terrified of him. "Golly," the actor portraying Mr. Starmer says, "what if Donald shouts at me?"

Mr. Trump's decision to distribute the skit to millions of his followers is the latest presidential disparagement of his British counterpart. In recent weeks, the president has mercilessly mocked Mr. Starmer as cowardly and spineless because of his unwillingness to fully join the fight against Iran. Mr. Trump has repeatedly said that Mr. Starmer is "No Winston Churchill" and chided him for not clearing the way for U.S. jets to use British bases for the initial strikes.

"We don't need people that join Wars after we've already won!" the president wrote on March 7.

For Mr. Starmer, who has spent more than a year trying to be Europe's Trump whisperer, the very public crumbling of their relationship comes at an already difficult time. Ukraine still needs American support to defend itself against Russia, a key priority for the British government. Mr. Starmer is fighting the perception that he refuses to take firm stands on policy. And now, the conflict with Iran is further damaging the already wobbly British economy.

The prime minister continues to talk privately with the president — including a 20-minute call on Sunday evening not long after the president circulated the "S.N.L. U.K." skit online — but it's unclear how much sway he has. What started early in 2025 with Mr. Trump praising Mr. Starmer for doing "a very good job," has now reached the stage where the prime minister is repeatedly insisting that the "special relationship" between Britain and the United States still exists. (In the "S.N.L. U.K." skit, it is referred to as the "special situationship.")

A spokesman for Mr. Starmer declined on Monday to say whether the prime minister had seen the skit or had discussed it

Continued on Page A8

Justices Seem to Back Trump on Denying Asylum at the Border

Parsing Right to Apply if Not Fully Across

By ANN E. MARIMOW

WASHINGTON — A majority of Supreme Court justices seemed sympathetic on Tuesday to the idea that the Trump administration should be able to turn away asylum seekers along the U.S.-Mexico border.

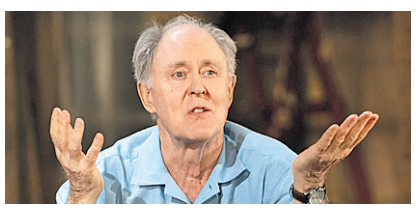
If the court backs the administration, it will allow President Trump to revive a policy first used in 2016, in which the government stopped asylum seekers from setting foot on U.S. soil, where federal law would entitle them to try to claim asylum and receive protection from persecution.

Under federal law, any noncitizen who is "physically present in the United States" or "arrives in the United States" can apply for asylum. Migrants who announce their intention to do so are then referred for an interview to determine whether they have a credible fear of persecution.

At issue in the case is whether noncitizens must fully cross the border to gain the right to apply for asylum or whether they must be allowed to apply if they merely appear at the border and seek entry.

The Supreme Court's conservative majority has generally been receptive to the Trump administration's assertions of presidential power, in a series of temporary orders that have allowed President Trump to implement his policies while litigation plays out in the lower courts. But last month the justices, including two of Mr. Trump's nominees, invalidated

Continued on Page A16



ARTS C1-6

Showing an Author's Ugly Side
John Lithgow, starring in a play about Roald Dahl's antisemitism, is a study in monstrosity, our critic says. PAGE C1

When Banksy Was Arrested
The artist was nabbed in 2000 for trying to deface a billboard, which may have eventually led to his unmasking. PAGE C1

NATIONAL A12-21

Bad Job Market for Graduates
Young degree holders are victims of a "low-hire, low-fire" labor dynamic in their search for entry-level positions in white-collar fields. PAGE A19

Changing Lesson Plans
In classrooms across the country, educators are weighing whether to shift the focus from Cesar Chavez to the labor movement he helped lead. PAGE A21

Fireball Fever From the Sky
After a seven-ton meteor exploded above Ohio, a group of meteorite hunters descended too, in the name of science, and possibly cash. PAGE A12

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Rethinking a Legendary Slog
New research suggests that a 200-mile march by Harold Godwinson, the last Anglo-Saxon king of England, may have actually involved some ships. PAGE A4

Worries About Kremlin Spying
A Russian oil tanker heading toward Cuba highlights Moscow's and Beijing's monitoring outposts. PAGE A10

SPORTS B7-11

Bold Predictions for 2026
Don't be astonished by Roman Anthony as an M.V.P., dominant Mets pitching or a Royals run to the playoffs. PAGE B7

FOOD D1-8

Fast-Food Chains Look North
Executives at Chick-fil-A, Popeyes, Raising Cane's and now Bojangles have their eyes fixed on New York. PAGE D7

Making Jacket Potatoes Sexy
The British classic has had a culinary resurgence of late, thanks partly to a creative social media effort. PAGE D1

BUSINESS B1-5

Downward Mobility in China
The Chinese dream that hard work would lead to a better life than their parents is coming apart. PAGE B1

BuzzFeed Comeback Plan
Facing financial straits, the founder is betting on a subsidiary that will use A.I. to build new applications. PAGE B1

OPINION A24-25

E.J. Dionne Jr. PAGE A24

0 354613 9